

INTEGRATED MARKETING PLAN PROJECT FOR: MUSH

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Marketing Strategy 660

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Executive Memo

To: MUSH Leadership Team

From: Shreyash Lokhare, Prasanna Saudagar, Kunal Pingale

Subject: Repositioning MUSH as a Daily Functional Breakfast Solution

Date: 05/13/2026

PURPOSE

The purpose of this marketing plan is to provide MUSH with a practical strategy to improve consumer retention, strengthen differentiation, and increase long-term customer value. MUSH has already built a strong brand around clean ingredients, convenience, and wellness. However, the brand now needs to move beyond being seen as a healthy lifestyle product and become a dependable breakfast solution that consumers can use regularly.

BACKGROUND

Our analysis across the semester shows that MUSH performs well in clean-label positioning, ready-to-eat convenience, and modern wellness appeal. These are important strengths. However, the breakfast market has changed. Consumers, especially students, young professionals, and active lifestyle consumers, are not only looking for something clean and convenient. They also want protein, fullness, energy, and value for regular use. (*Mintel, 2025; IFIC, 2024*)

This creates a commercial risk: MUSH may continue generating trial through clean-label appeal, but lose repeat purchase because consumers do not see the product as filling or functional enough for daily breakfast use. Competitors such as Kodiak and Oats Overnight are stronger in protein and satiety positioning. (*Mintel, 2025; Target, 2025*). Because of this, MUSH may attract first-time trials, but it risks losing consumers if the product is not seen as filling enough for everyday breakfast.

RECOMMENDATION

We recommend that MUSH reposition itself from a “healthy lifestyle snack” to a “daily functional breakfast system.”

This repositioning should be supported by three moves:

- Strengthen functional positioning around protein, fullness, and sustained morning energy.
- Improve repeat purchase through subscription packs, loyalty rewards, and personalized CRM.
- Create product and campaign differentiation through Protein Boost Add-On Packs and the campaign message:

“Don’t Skip. Stay Full. Stay Sharp.”

NEXT STEPS

Over the next 6–12 months, MUSH should update its brand communication, launch sampling campaigns, test product add-ons, build a subscription model, and track repeat purchase behavior closely. The most important goal is not only to get consumers to try MUSH once, but to make MUSH part of their weekly breakfast routine.

1. Situation Assessment and Analysis

1.1 Company and Market Context

MUSH is a ready-to-eat overnight oats brand positioned around clean ingredients, convenience, and wellness. (*MUSH Foods Inc., 2025*). The brand fits well into today's breakfast market because many consumers want healthier food options that save time in the morning. MUSH's refrigerated format, simple ingredient story, and lifestyle-based brand image help it stand out from highly processed breakfast products.

However, the category is becoming more competitive. Consumers now compare breakfast products not only on convenience and health, but also on protein, fullness, price value, and how well the product supports their daily routine. This is important because breakfast is no longer just a convenience occasion; it is increasingly evaluated as a functional nutrition decision. (*Mintel, 2025; Technomic, 2024*). This means MUSH cannot depend only on its clean-label appeal. To grow, MUSH must show that it can work as a complete breakfast, not just a quick snack.

Figure 1: Breakfast Market Shift

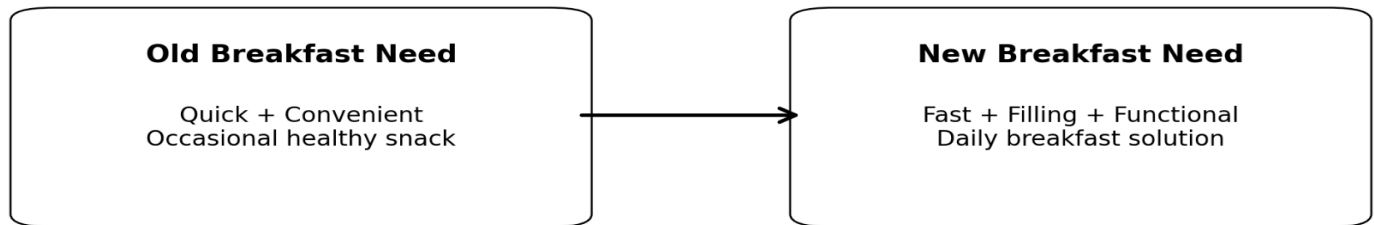


Fig.1: The breakfast market shifts from quick convenience to functional daily breakfast.

Source: Author analysis based on *Mintel (2025)*, *IFIC (2024)*, and prior checkpoint analysis.

The key shift in the market is clear. Consumers are moving from “I need something quick” to “I need something quick, healthy, filling, and useful for my day.” This shift creates an opportunity for MUSH to strengthen its role in the consumer’s morning routine.

1.2 Core Business Problem

The main problem is not awareness. MUSH already has strong lifestyle appeal and is visible among wellness-focused consumers. The bigger problem is that many consumers do not yet see MUSH as strong enough to become their daily breakfast. (*Target, 2025*)

MUSH currently wins on:

Strength	Why it Matters
Clean ingredients	Builds trust with health-conscious consumers
Ready-to-eat convenience	Solves the morning time problem
Modern wellness image	Fits social media and lifestyle trends
Simple branding	Easy to understand and communicate

However, MUSH is weaker on:

Weakness	Business Risk
Lower protein perception	Makes the product feel less functional
Weak satiety/fullness	Reduces repeat purchase
Premium price	Creates value concerns
Limited customization	Reduces fit for different nutrition needs
Lifestyle-heavy messaging	Makes it feel like a snack, not a meal

The core business issue is therefore a value perception gap. (*Euromonitor International, 2024; Target, 2025*). MUSH looks attractive and healthy, but consumers may not feel that it gives enough protein, satiety, or value to justify regular purchase.

1.3 Competitive Landscape

MUSH competes with both direct oat-based brands and broader breakfast alternatives. Oats Overnight and Kodiak are important competitors because they represent the high-protein and performance-focused side of the market. (Mintel, 2025; Technomic, 2024)

Factor	MUSH	Oats Overnight	Kodiak
Format	Ready to eat cold oats	Mixed/Overnight format	Instant hot Oatmeal
Protein	Lower	High	High
Convenience	High	Medium	Medium
Clean Label	Strong	Medium	Medium
Satiety	Low	High	High
Customization	Low	High	Low
Price Value	Medium	Medium	Strong

MUSH is strong in clean convenience, but competitors are stronger in protein and breakfast performance. (Mintel, 2025; Target, 2025). This creates a clear competitive challenge. If consumers are choosing breakfast to stay full and energized, MUSH must prove that it can deliver more than clean ingredients.

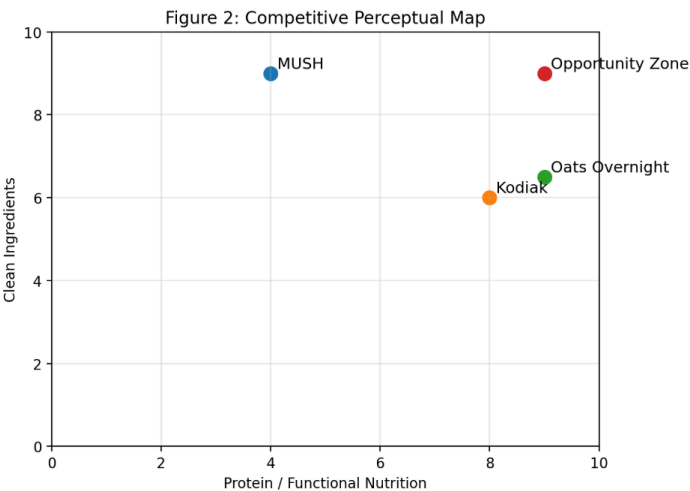


Figure 2: Competitive perceptual map showing MUSH’s opportunity to move toward high-protein and clean breakfast positioning.

Source: Author analysis based on competitor positioning, product claims, and prior checkpoint analysis.

The opportunity zone is the space where clean ingredients and functional nutrition come together. MUSH already has credibility in clean ingredients. The next step is to build credibility in protein, satiety, and breakfast performance.

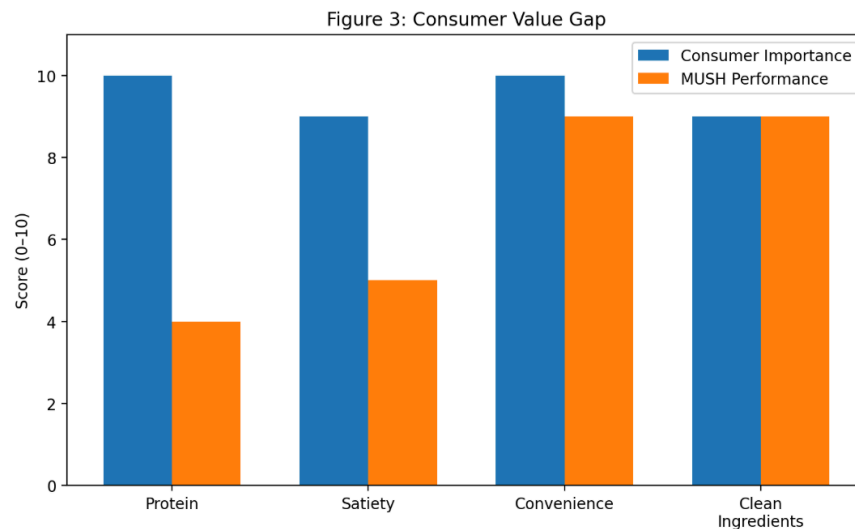


Figure 3: Consumer Value Gap, Consumer Importance vs. MUSH Performance

Source: Author analysis based on *Mintel (2025)*, *IFIC (2024)*, *Target customer reviews (2025)*, and prior checkpoint findings.

Figure 3 shows the gap between what consumers value most and how MUSH currently performs on those factors. MUSH performs strongly in convenience and clean ingredients, but it underperforms in protein and satiety. This is important because protein and fullness are key factors for consumers who want a complete breakfast. The gap supports our recommendation that MUSH should strengthen its functional positioning and improve its value as a daily breakfast solution.

1.4 Target Consumer

The primary target segment is busy, health-conscious students and young professionals. (*Statista, 2024; IFIC, 2024*) These consumers are usually between 18 and 34 years old. They have busy mornings, often balance school, work, gym, and social responsibilities, and frequently look for quick food options. They are active on Instagram, TikTok, and online review platforms. (*Solomon, 2020*). They are also influenced by peer recommendations, influencers, and convenience-based food habits.

Attribute	Description
Age	18-34
Lifestyle	Busy mornings, school, work, gym, commuting
Main Need	Quick, healthy, filling breakfast
Pain Point	Skips breakfast or eats unhealthy options
Purchase Driver	Protein, convenience, taste, clean ingredients, value
Media Behaviour	Instagram, TikTok, influencers, online reviews

The target consumer does not simply want oats. They want a better morning routine. Their real need is:

“I need something fast, healthy, and filling before my day starts.”

This insight is important because it changes how MUSH should communicate. Instead of selling only clean oats, MUSH should sell energy, control, and confidence in the morning.

1.5 Consumer Journey Insight

The consumer journey shows that the largest weakness is not at the awareness stage. The weakness appears between trial and repeat purchase. (Kotler and Keller, 2016; Solomon, 2020)

Journey Stage	Consumer Behaviour	Mush Challenge
Awareness	Sees MUSH online or in-store	Awareness is already strong
Engagement	Likes clean and convenient image	Needs stronger functional proof
Trial	Buys once to test taste and value	Needs sampling and promotions
Repeat	Decides if it is filling enough	Weak if satiety/protein is not strong
Loyalty	Adds product to routine	Requires CRM, subscription, rewards

Breakfast is a repeat category. If MUSH does not become part of a weekly routine, it will remain an occasional trial product. That is why the strategy must focus on habit formation, not only awareness. (Bain & Company, 2024; Harvard Business Review, 2024)

Marketing Objective

The main marketing objective is:

To reposition MUSH as a complete functional breakfast solution and increase repeat purchase by improving functional messaging, trial conversion, and customer retention. *(Kotler and Keller, 2016)*

Supporting objectives:

Objective	Desired Outcome
Strengthen Positioning	Move from snack perception to breakfast solution
Increase Trial	Use sampling, bundles, and student promotions
Improve Retention	Launch subscription and loyalty systems
Increase CLV	Improve repeat purchase and customer relationship value
Build Differentiation	Own clean convenience + functional nutrition

This objective is practical because it builds on MUSH's existing strengths while solving the biggest weakness: repeat purchase.

Marketing Strategy & Tactics

3.1 Positioning Strategy

Current Positioning

MUSH is currently seen as clean, convenient, modern, and wellness-focused. This is valuable, but it is not enough to win in a competitive breakfast market where consumers also expect protein and fullness.

Recommended Positioning

MUSH should be positioned as:

A clean, ready-to-eat breakfast that helps busy consumers stay full, energized, and in control of their morning.

Positioning Shift

From	To
Healthy Snack	Daily Breakfast Solution
Clean Eating	Clean + Functional Nutrition
Convenience	Convenience + Satiety
Lifestyle Brand	Functional Breakfast System
Trial Purchase	Daily Habit

This repositioning is faithful to the brand because it does not remove MUSH's clean-label identity. It adds a stronger functional layer to the same brand story. *(Kotler and Keller, 2016)*

3.2 Core Strategic Platform

Strategy: Build the "Powered Morning" Platform

The strongest opportunity for MUSH is to build a full morning routine platform around energy, fullness, and convenience.

Platform Name

"Powered Morning by MUSH"

Campaign Message

“Don’t Skip. Stay Full. Stay Sharp.”

This message works because it directly connects to the consumer’s real morning problem: *(Solomon, 2020)*

Message Element	Meaning
Don't Skip	Addresses breakfast skipping
Stay Full	Addresses satiety need
Stay Sharp	Addresses energy and productivity

This is stronger than simply saying “clean oats” because it tells consumers what the product helps them do.

3.3 Product and Innovation Strategy

MUSH should improve functional value without losing its clean-label identity. *(MUSH Foods Inc., 2025; Mintel, 2025)*

Recommendation 1: Protein Boost Add-On Packs

MUSH should introduce optional Protein Boost Add-On Packs that consumers can mix with MUSH products.

This creates customization without changing the core product for every consumer. It also helps fitness-focused and high-protein consumers see MUSH as more functional.

Why this works:

- Adds customization
- Supports fitness and satiety needs
- Gives consumers control
- Differentiates MUSH from standard ready-to-eat oats

Recommendation 2: Subscription Breakfast Kits

MUSH should launch weekly subscription packs.

Example: Power Your Week Pack, Includes:

- 7 ready-to-eat breakfasts
- rotating flavors

- optional protein boost
- lower cost per serving
- loyalty points

This helps MUSH move from one-time trial to repeat behavior. Since breakfast is a routine category, subscription can increase purchase frequency and customer lifetime value. *(Bain & Company, 2024; Harvard Business Review, 2024)*

Recommendation 3: Campus and Gym Bundles

MUSH should offer bundles through universities, gyms, wellness events, and office breakfast programs.

These locations matter because they are places where the breakfast problem actually happens. Students, gym-goers, and young professionals often need quick nutrition during busy mornings.

3.4 Integrated Marketing Communication Strategy

The IMC strategy should shift from lifestyle awareness to conversion and retention. *(Kotler and Keller, 2016)*

IMC Tool	Current Role	Recommended Role
Advertising	Lifestyle visuals	Protein, energy, satiety messaging
Social Media	One-way Content	UGC, challenges, comments, reviews
Influencers	Aesthetic wellness	Morning routine + fitness credibility
Sales Promotion	Limited	Sampling, bundles, student discounts
PR	Founder Story	Functional breakfast story
Sponsorship	Limited	Gyms, colleges, wellness events
Direct Marketing	General Emails	Personalized repeat-purchase reminders

The goal is not more communication. The goal is better communication that answers the consumer’s real question: *(Solomon, 2020; IFIC, 2024)*

“Will this keep me full and energized?”

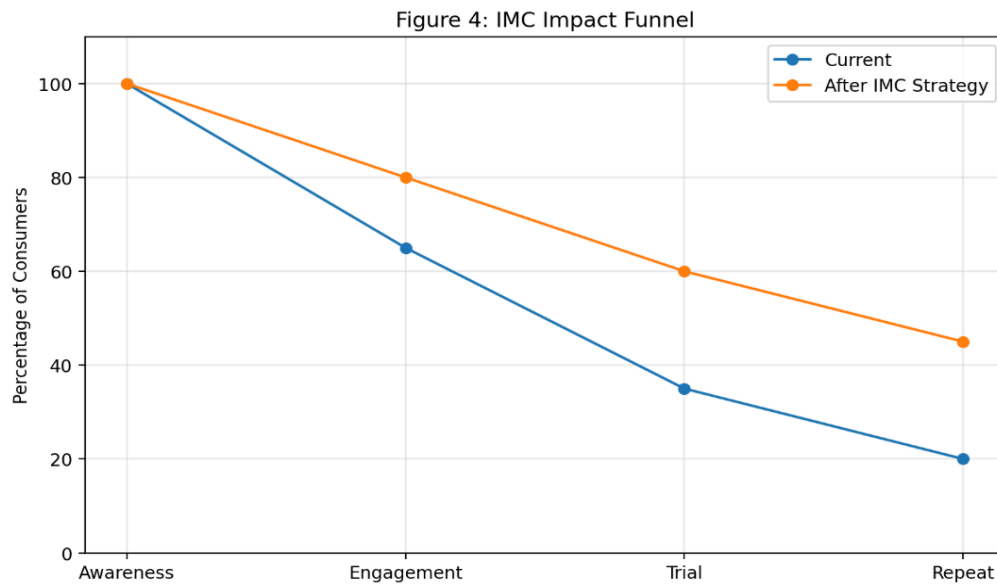


Figure 4. Expected improvement in customer conversion after IMC strategy implementation.

Source: Author analysis based on *Nielsen (2024)*, *Mintel (2025)*, and IMC campaign benchmarks.

This figure shows that the biggest expected improvement is not awareness. The real improvement should happen in trial and repeat purchase. Sampling, functional messaging, and stronger retention tactics should help more consumers move from interest to actual use.

3.5 Campaign Execution Plan

Campaign: “Don’t Skip. Stay Full. Stay Sharp.”

The campaign should make MUSH feel like a reliable morning solution, not just an occasional snack.

Digital Strategy

Use Instagram, TikTok, and influencer content to show real morning routines.

Content ideas:

- “Before MUSH vs After MUSH” morning routine reels
- “What I eat before class/work/gym”

- “2-minute breakfast challenge”
- “Powered Morning” user stories
- Influencer Strategy

Use two types of influencers:

Influencer Type	Role
Fitness Creators	Build protein and performance credibility
Lifestyle Creators	Build routine and relatability

Fitness creators should focus on energy, protein, gym use, and post-workout convenience. Lifestyle creators should focus on morning routine, productivity, and healthy habits.

Experiential Strategy

Sampling is important because food adoption depends on taste, texture, and fullness. *(Nielsen, 2024; Solomon, 2020)*. Consumers may like the idea of MUSH online, but they need to experience the product before making it part of their routine.

Recommended activations:

- campus morning pop-ups
- gym sampling booths
- student discount weeks
- office wellness breakfast events

Retention Strategy

After first purchase, MUSH should guide consumers into CRM programs:

- subscription offers
- loyalty rewards
- personalized email reminders
- referral discounts
- flavor preference recommendations

This campaign is not only about getting attention. It is about building a repeat breakfast habit. *(Kotler and Keller, 2016; Bain & Company, 2024)*

3.6 CRM and Customer Lifetime Value Strategy

MUSH should shift from a product-first mindset to a relationship-first mindset. *(Bain & Company, 2024; Harvard Business Review, 2024)*

Current Issue

MUSH is strong at attracting trials, but weaker at building long-term behavior. This is a major opportunity because breakfast is a high-frequency category.

Recommended CRM Shift

From	To
One Time Purchase	Repeat Purchase
Product Brand	Relationship Brand
Awareness Marketing	Retention Marketing
Occasional Use	Breakfast Habit
Consumer Transaction	Consumer lifetime Value

Powered Morning Club

MUSH should launch a membership ecosystem called Powered Morning Club.

Benefits:

- subscription discounts
- early access to new flavors
- birthday offers
- loyalty points
- referral rewards
- personalized recommendations

Figure 5: Customer Equity Pyramid

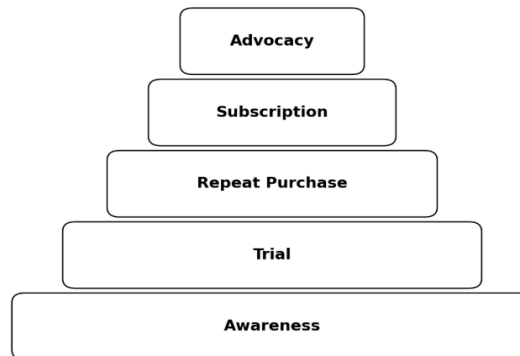


Figure 5: Customer equity path for moving consumers from awareness to advocacy.

Source: Author adaptation based on customer equity and CRM strategy concepts.

The goal is to move consumers from awareness to trial, then repeat purchase, then subscription, and finally advocacy. This is important because long-term profitability depends more on repeat purchase and retention than only first-time acquisition. (*Bain & Company, 2024; Harvard Business Review, 2024*)

Controls

4.1 KPI Dashboard

MUSH should evaluate the strategy using clear business metrics. (*Kotler and Keller, 2016*)

Objective	KPI	Target
Increase Trial	Sampling Conversion Rate	20-25% Improvement
Improve Retention	Repeat Purchase Rate	15-20% Improvement
Build Engagement	Social Engagement Rate	30% Improvement
Grow Loyalty	Subscription Retention	Monthly Tracking
Increase Profitability	Customer Lifetime Value	Quarterly Tracking
Improve Satisfaction	Reviews	Monthly Tracking

These KPIs should be reviewed consistently. If trial improves but repeat purchase does not, MUSH should focus on product experience, satiety, and value communication. If engagement is high but sales conversion is low, the brand should increase sampling and trial offers.

4.2 Implementation Roadmap

Figure 6: 12-Month Implementation Roadmap

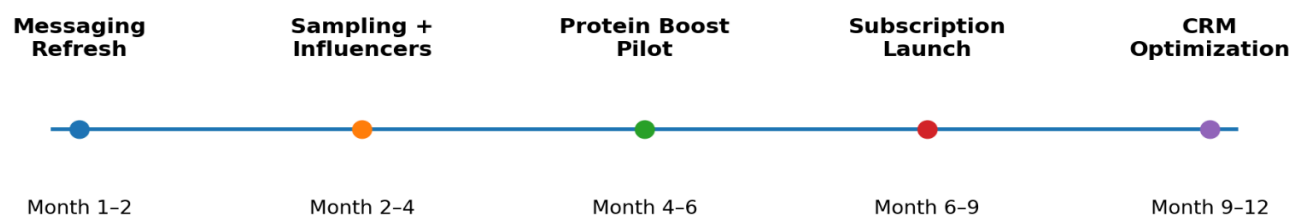


Figure 6: Recommended 12-month implementation roadmap for MUSH.

Source: Author analysis based on proposed marketing strategy and implementation plan.

Phase	Timeline	Action
Phase 1	Month 1-2	Update positioning and messaging
Phase 2	Month 2-4	Launch sampling and influencer campaign
Phase 3	Month 4-6	Launch Protein Boost Add-On pilot
Phase 4	Month 6-9	Launch subscription model
Phase 5	Month 9-12	Optimize CRM and retention programs

This roadmap is realistic because it does not require MUSH to change everything at once. It starts with messaging, then builds trials, then adds product innovation, and finally strengthens CRM.

4.3 Monitoring and Adaptation Plan

MUSH should use a monthly and quarterly review system.

Monthly Review

Track:

- repeat purchase
- subscription retention
- review sentiment
- campaign engagement
- email conversion
- flavor preference data

Quarterly Review

Evaluate:

- channel performance
- customer segment response
- campaign ROI
- product feedback
- CLV improvement
- subscription churn

Decision Rules

If This Happens	Then MUSH Should
Trial is high but repeat is low	Improve satiety messaging and product experience
Engagement is high but conversion is low	Add stronger promotions and sampling
Subscription churn is high	Improve pricing, flexibility, and flavor variety
Reviews mention low protein	Promote Protein Boost option more strongly
Price complaints increase	Add bundles, student pricing, and subscription savings

These controls make the strategy practical and adaptable. MUSH should not wait until the end of the year to judge performance. It should use live feedback to improve the campaign and product experience.

Overall Value of Recommendation

Feasible

This strategy is realistic because MUSH already has strong brand awareness, social media presence, retail access, and clean-label credibility. The plan does not require a full brand change. It strengthens what MUSH already does well and adds clearer functional value.

Faithful

The strategy stays true to MUSH's identity. It does not move away from clean ingredients or wellness. Instead, it adds protein, satiety, and morning performance to the existing clean-label story.

Favorable

The plan directly responds to consumer demand for protein, fullness, convenience, and health. It also improves repeat purchase, customer loyalty, and customer lifetime value. These are important because MUSH's long-term growth depends on becoming part of the consumer's daily routine.

Final Recommendation

MUSH should stop competing only as a clean lifestyle product and start building ownership of the daily functional breakfast space.

Final Strategic Statement

MUSH already owns clean and convenient. To win long-term, it must have its own protein, fullness, and morning performance.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Suggested Figures

- Breakfast Market Shift Diagram
- Competitive Perceptual Map
- Consumer Value Gap Chart
- IMC Impact Funnel
- Customer Equity Pyramid
- 12-Month Implementation Roadmap

Appendix B: Implementation Checklist

Task	Owner	Timeline
Update core message across website and packaging	Brand/Marketing Team	Month 1-2
Launch “Don’t Skip. Stay Full. Stay Sharp.” campaign	Marketing Team	Month 2
Identify 10–15 micro-influencers	Social Media Team	Month 2
Launch campus and gym sampling pilots	Field Marketing Team	Month 2-4
Test Protein Boost Add-On Packs	Product Team	Month 4-6
Launch Powered Morning Club subscription	CRM Team	Month 6-9
Track trial, repeat purchase, CLV, and reviews	Analytics Team	Ongoing

Appendix C: Campaign Message Examples

- “Don’t Skip. Stay Full. Stay Sharp.”
- “Clean breakfast. Real energy.”
- “Ready in seconds. Built for your morning.”
- “Your daily breakfast, upgraded.”
- “From a quick snack to complete morning fuel.”

Appendix D: Sample Social Media Campaign Ideas

Content Idea	Purpose
"My Powered Morning" challenge	User-generated content
"2-minute breakfast before class" reel	Student relevance
"Before gym / after gym MUSH routine"	Fitness credibility
"What keeps me full until lunch?" post	Satiety communication
"Protein Boost your MUSH" demo	Product innovation awareness